



Defending the markers of masculinity: Consumer resistance to brand gender-bending

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ABSTRACT

I study the Porsche Cayenne SUV launch to ethnographically analyze how men consuming a gendered brand respond to perceived brand gender contamination. The consumers' communal gender work in a Porsche brand community is analyzed to uncover brand gender contamination's effects on the identity projects of consumers, the brand as an identity marker, and the prevailing gender order in the group. Through the promulgation of gender stereotypes, Porsche owners stratify themselves along gender lines and create an ingroup that is sharply defined by masculinity and an outgroup that is defined by femininity. The construction of social barriers limits access to Porsche's meanings to those who achieve masculine ideals and causes the SUV owners to resort to hyper-masculine behaviors to combat exclusion. The consumers' gender work reverses the firm's efforts to gender-bend the brand, reinstates Porsche as a masculine marker, and reifies particular definitions of masculinity in the community.

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1. Introduction

"It's a boy!" claims Volkswagen in the 2012 relaunch of its Beetle. The Beetle's more aggressive design was devised to bring men into the female-skewed customer base. Harley-Davidson once claimed that it made "big toys for big boys"; today, the company is trying to attract women. Marketers are gender-bending their brands, taking products that had been targeted to one sex and targeting them to the other. In the postmodern era, both men and women have engaged in gender-bending consumption, co-opting the consumption practices and products of the opposite sex to play with definitions of gender and support new ideologies. Consumer researchers argue that we are in a post-gender period in which the stark lines that have historically divided men's and women's consumption are blurring (Firat, 1994; Patterson & Elliott, 2002). Have we finally reached a time when gender does not matter in consumption? Can brands transcend their gendered roots and become neither masculine nor feminine, but an androgynous mixture of both?

Throughout history, our consumption has been gendered and consumers have relied on gendered products and brands as props to perform their gender identities. In 1994, Fischer and Gainer (1994: 101) hypothesized that gendered consumption was ubiquitous and enduring:

If we find...that most consumption domains are gendered, and not particularly susceptible to revision in this regard, we will begin to have a better appreciation of the ways that consumption practices

are shaped by and support other mutually reinforcing social practices that contribute to the current gender order.

Gender still takes center stage in many brand narratives, and brands often find it difficult to attract the opposite sex to brands associated with one sex. Pepsi and Coke launched new brands to attract men to diet soda after their efforts to sell Diet Pepsi and Diet Coke to men were unsuccessful. PepsiMax, Coke Zero, and Dr. Pepper Ten work hard to distance themselves from feminine diet sodas by claiming that they are the "diet cola for men" and "it's not for women." When entering the more feminine body wash category, Gillette infused its advertising with masculine images of power tools and footballs and encouraged men to "wash like a man, feel like a man," while Dove for Men featured men in traditional roles, acting as a protector and lifting weights, reassuring men that their masculinity would be preserved if they used the product. Despite consumers' gender-bending consumption, gender appears to remain an important organizing construct in branding.

In this article, I analyze consumers' lived experience and collective response to the gender-bending of their brands by exploring consumption in situ to understand the role that gender plays in today's postmodern world. I explore two research questions: How do consumers respond to the appropriation of their brands by the opposite sex and how does their response affect the brands' potency as a gendered identity marker? I first illuminate how consumers use brands to enact gender and why the gender contamination of brands occurs. Then, I describe my design for the study of consumers' response to the gender-bending of Porsche via the launch of an SUV that attracted women to the masculine brand. I outline the SUV's identity threat and analyze the existing owners' collective impression management

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practices. I show that the consumers who rely on a brand's gendered identity respond to gender-bending by fighting for their brand rather than discarding it. In fighting, the consumers strengthen the brand's gendered meanings, paradoxically increasing its potency as an identity marker as the other sex encroaches. The consumers' gender work reverses the firm's efforts to gender-bend the brand, reinstates the brand as a masculine marker, and reifies the particular definitions of masculinity in the brand community. I conclude with a discussion of the theoretical and managerial implications of gender-bending branding.

2. Theoretical foundations

2.1. Enacting gender through consumption

Our most salient and central identity in the multitude of identities that define us is our sense of ourselves as being male or female. We rely heavily on gender to define ourselves and to classify and understand others (Deaux & LaFrance, 1998). Gender, unlike sex, is not biologically determined; instead, it is a socially accomplished, culturally constituted ongoing construction project. We are not granted a gender at birth; we perform our gender through situated, symbolic social interaction (West & Zimmerman, 1987). We construct gender in social interactions by tailoring our actions to conform (or not) to the normative conceptions of masculinity and femininity that exist in our culture (Gherardi, 1995) by choosing from a cultural repertoire of gendered behaviors (Wetherell & Edley, 1999). These practices, in turn, create a social gender display that reinforces (or resists) the prevailing conceptions of masculinity and femininity (Butler, 1990; Lorber, 1994). Although many different forms of masculinity and femininity exist concurrently in a particular culture (Carrigan, Connell, & Lee, 1985), one form is held as the taken-for-granted hegemonic standard. All people might not adhere to the hegemonic definitions, but these definitions inform people's actions and how others interpret them (Spence & Helmreich, 1978).

Gender display is often accomplished through the use of props (Lorber, 1994). We create, enhance, and accomplish our gender identities through consumption and, thus, our possessions function as symbolic gender identity markers. Penaloza (1994) suggests that there are separate masculine and feminine consumer cultures that define what is appropriate (and inappropriate) for each gender to purchase and consume, while others support that possessions, brands, and consumption behaviors and practices are gendered (cf. Fischer & Arnould, 1990; Sherry, Kozinets, Duhachek, et al., 2004; Wallendorf & Arnould, 1991). Gendered brands contain either masculine or feminine identity meanings that are socially shared among the members of a culture. We adorn our gender displays with these brands as tangible markers; gendered brands help materialize gender, enlivening who we are as men or women. Brands populate the universe of choices that we make to express our gender, and men and women generally prefer and choose brands, possessions, and activities that reflect their gender identity (as reviewed in Palan, 2001; Stern, 1988).

2.2. The constraining forces of gendered consumption

The gendering of brands constrains what we buy, given the strong polarization of gender in many cultures, where what is feminine is understood to be the antithesis of what is masculine (Bem, 1993). When we do gender "appropriately" through consumption, our practices sustain and reinforce the prevailing roles (Fischer & Gainer, 1994; Gherardi, 1995) and people understand who we are or would like to be. When we engage in gender-bending practices by co-opting the products of the opposite sex, we are often called to account and our gender identity is questioned (Kramer, 2005). Through our performative acts, we reinforce the regulative gender discourses

(Butler, 1990) the cultural narratives that outline proper behavior (Borgerson & Schroeder, 2004).

The political nature of gender has a differential effect on men and women. Androcentrism reigns in most cultures, where masculinity is more highly valued and is seen as normal, while femininity is deviant from and less than masculinity (Kramer, 2005). Hegemonic masculinity in many cultures has been defined as misogynistic and patriarchal (Connell, 1993) and includes "the dread of and the flight from women," (Donaldson, 1993: 645). Women and women's things signify not only femininity but also a lack of masculinity. The most important rule of manhood is to not be like a woman; real men "must never, never resemble women, or display strongly stereotyped feminine characteristics" (Brannon, 1976:14). Most men manage their masculinity through consumption to ward off fears that others will see them as effeminate or gay (Carrigan et al., 1985; Kimmel, 1996). For men striving to achieve masculinity, success largely depends upon renouncing the feminine (Conway-Long, 1994; Cornwall & Lindisfarne, 1994), and this constraint circumscribes male consumers' choices to those that fall within the regulative boundaries (Borgerson & Schroeder, 2004; Rinaldo, 2007).

Research suggests that using feminine brands carries a greater stigma for men than using masculine brands does for women. While both men and women prefer brands that express their own gender identity, women are more likely to purchase masculine brands than men are likely to purchase feminine brands (Fry, 1971; Vitz & Johnson, 1965; Worth, Smith, & Mackie, 1992). Penaloza (1994: 366, 374) attributes this preference to differential power dynamics at work:

Because most of those with money and power are men, the crossing of women into the male domain by wearing clothes associated with the masculine is viewed as rational and is naturalized, whereas for men, to cross into the feminine domain by wearing clothing associated with the feminine is to willingly pursue its stigma and downward mobility, which is viewed as irrational and it goes against individual male privilege and the male dominated culture.

2.3. Gender-bending consumption and gender contamination

First and second wave feminists appropriated men's consumption symbols to fight for gender equality by tossing aside the vestiges of femininity (Hollows, 2000; McCracken, 1988) and adopting short haircuts, cigarette smoking, and masculine fashion styles. Even the most masculine of enclaves, the Harley-Davidson brand community (Martin, Schouten, & McAlexander, 2006) and The Citadel, the all-male military college (Addelston & Stirratt, 1996), were infiltrated by women, many of whom used the oppositional tension generated by their consumption to create alternative femininities.

The emergence of the metrosexual discourse in the 1990s appeared to usher in the deconstruction of gender and a move toward the androgynous consumption that was promised by postmodern theory in which bricoleur consumers circumvent constraining categories by composing a multifaceted and creative self through their consumption (Holt & Thompson, 2004; Thompson & Haytko, 1997). The metrosexual was a media-proliferated masculine ideology (Simpson, 1994) that emerged as an alternative to traditional masculinity and gave license to men to pursue consumption activities that were never before deemed acceptable. Young, urban, heterosexual men began buying products that had been associated with women or homosexual men (Bordo, 1999; Crane, 1999). Through their countercultural consumption, metrosexuals redefined the boundaries of masculine consumption by disarticulating practices that were previously associated with women and homosexuals and resignifying them as appropriate for heterosexual men.

However, given the political and power disparity that still exists between men and women, women's gender-bending consumption

might be more dangerous to men than men's gender-bending consumption is to women. The gender contamination of brands might occur as men searching for masculine distinction work to avoid brands that are used by women and/or abandon previously masculine brands that have been infiltrated by women (McCracken, 1988; Tuncay & Otnes, 2008). Anthropologists have documented gender-related totems and talismans from multiple cultures and historical periods that are associated with men, which women are forbidden to see, touch, or use (Herdt, 1981). Addeleston and Stirratt (1996) document a contemporary masculinity marker, the Citadel graduation ring, that is contaminated by the touch of a woman.

The symbolic interactionists (Mead, 1934) theorized that the meaning of a symbolic gesture, such as the use of a brand, is a social product revealed in an audience's response to it. Meaning is dynamic and socially constituted. The fact that a brand's identity meanings are common knowledge is a necessary condition for the use of the brand as an identity marker; consumers not only have to interpret the brand's identity meanings for themselves, but they have to know that other people in their relevant social audiences will interpret them in the same way.

Gender contamination threatens this shared interpretation of a brand's meaning, and people might find it more difficult to create their identity through consumption as the practices, products, and brands that are traditionally associated with masculinity or femininity are appropriated by the opposite sex. Gender-bending branding might generate reflected appraisals that are inconsistent with the message that the brand's customers are trying to send. People feel "out of face" (Goffman, 1959) when their reflected appraisals do not reflect who they want to be. Feeling out of face is psychologically uncomfortable and motivates identity practices to alleviate the incongruence (Burke, 1991). Distress increases when the identity in question is a central part of the person's overall identity and when the person is highly committed to the identity, as is often the case with gender (Burke, 1991; Swann & Ely, 1984). Saving face (Goffman, 1959) involves practices designed to influence the audience so that their reflected appraisals move back into congruence with the desired identity.

Under identity threat, people tend to immerse themselves in social environments in which their desired identities are supported, and they isolate themselves from the environments in which they are not (McCall & Simmons, 1966). Research on the Star Trek (Kozinets, 2001), Apple Newton (Muniz & Schau, 2005), and Hummer (Luedicke, Thompson, & Giesler, 2009) brand communities shows that consumers look for the collective support of their brand brethren to defend against stigmatizing brand meanings. In today's world, saving face is likely to be both an individual and a collective practice undertaken in a brand's communities.

3. Method

Through a multimethod design, I analyzed existing consumers' phenomenological response to the gender-bending of their brand. This design allowed me to analyze the consumers' construction of their identity using brands as the brands moved through two moments of cultural production, following methods used by cultural historians (Denning, 1987; Illouz, 1997; Radway, 1984) and brought to consumer research by Holt and Thompson (2004). First, I observed the consumers' construction of identity through brands as it intersected with mass culture discourses, which serve as a repository of masculine meanings that are available for use. Second, I observed the consumers' construction of identity as it was enacted in day-to-day consumption practices.

3.1. Natural experiment of observation

Porsche shocked the world when it announced the launch of the Porsche Cayenne SUV, the first non-sports car in its seventy-year history. This event was chosen for this study based on the following

criteria. First, the Porsche brand serves as a strong example of a gendered brand, with a positioning described by prior researchers as "extreme masculinity" (Stuteville, 1971). Cars are an important part of many men's extended selves, and Belk (2004: 273) has claimed that "extreme identification with automobiles is a predominantly male fascination... There are few possessions as important to many adult American men as their cars." Some men experience their cars as a sexual extension of themselves (Belk, 2004; Lane & Sternberg, 1985). Sports cars, in particular, can serve as phallic symbols (Thompson & Holt, 2004), which increase the probability that identity concerns will be triggered if the gender meanings associated with a sports car brand are altered. Finally, the press surrounding the launch of the Porsche Cayenne suggested that the brand's gender identity meanings were changing, "Porsche goes soccer mom... Has Porsche lost its soul?" claimed *Forbes*, while *The New York Times* found, "There may be no vision more heretical to a testosterone-poisoned 911 owner than that of a suburban mother loading groceries into the back of her Porsche after dropping her children off at soccer practice."

3.2. Cultural discourse analysis

For some brands, especially those that have achieved the status of a cultural icon, gender identity meanings are reflected in and/or emerge from the mass mediated image that the brand enjoys in the culture (Holt, 2004). To understand brand meaning as conveyed by mass media depictions of the brand, one must understand the cultural stories in which the brand performs a supporting role by interpreting the symbolism of the brand's products as presented in cultural texts (Hirschman, 1988; Holbrook & Grayson, 1986). To understand Porsche's gender identity meanings, I conducted a cultural analysis of the Porsche brand in popular culture. I analyzed major American movies and television programs over a forty-year time period (see Table 1) that featured Porsche vehicles and extracted the identity characteristics shared by the characters driving them. I began my analysis using lists constructed by the brand community members and supplemented them with information from an online movie database.

3.3. Brand identity meaning elicitation experiment

To better understand Porsche's existing gender identity meanings as well as the new gender identity meanings brought by the SUV, I conducted an experiment. First, I elicited Porsche brand and SUV category gender identity meanings from consumers using an unaided elicitation task: "describe the type of person who drives a Porsche (an SUV)." The elicited meanings formed the basis of a study administered to MBA students at a large U.S. business school. The study consisted of a randomly assigned, between-subjects design that manipulated which portion of the Porsche product line was shown. Thirty-nine participants (sports car group) were given the Porsche brand logo and the photographs and names of the sports cars in the Porsche product line. Thirty-four participants (SUV group) were given the Porsche brand logo and the photograph and name of the Porsche Cayenne SUV. Gender and car/SUV ownership were balanced across the conditions, and no significant differences across groups were observed. Participants were asked to "describe the type of person who purchases and drives these Porsche vehicles" by completing a set of 23 semantic differential items consisting of bipolar scales anchored by contrasting meanings on each end of a 7-point scale (e.g., male/female). Additionally, participants used a 7-point Likert scale to measure their agreement with each of five additional identity meanings for which direct opposites did not exist (e.g., soccer mom).

3.4. Brand community netnography

Last, an historical archive of unfolding consumer-to-consumer conversations about the launch in an online Porsche brand community

Table 1

Cultural analysis of Porsche identity meanings.

Movie/television show	Porsche	(Actor or role)	Identity characteristics
Harper (1966)	356	Paul Newman	Cynical, cool P.I.
The Quiller Memorandum (1966)	356	George Segal	British spy, loner, unorthodox, dangerous, deadly
Downhill Racer (1969)	911	Robert Redford	Quietly cocky ski racer
Le Mans (1971)	911	Steve McQueen	Race car driver
The Return of the Dragon (1974)	356	"Bruce Lee"	Martial artist, fighter, good guy, super-hero
Grand Theft Auto (1977)	911		Snooty rich boy
Annie Hall (1977)	911	Christopher Walkin	Psycho, strange, suicidal, Yankee
FM (1978)	911	"Jeff Dugan"	Radio station manager
Good Guys Wear Black (1978)	930	Chuck Norris	Ex U.S. army commando
Private Benjamin (1980)	911	"Henri Alan Tremont"	Wealthy, self-absorbed, handsome, adulterer
Middle Age Crazy (1980)	928	Bruce Dern	40, having affair & mid-life crisis
American Gigolo (1980)	911		Bad guy pimp
Dogs of War (1980)	356	Christopher Walken	Mercenary, revolutionary hero
Arthur (1981)	924	Dudley Moore	Wealthy, lazy, playboy
Modern Problems (1981)	911	Dabney Coleman	Shady, egotistical author
Modern Romance (1981)	911	Albert Brooks	Jealous, self-centered, single, successful film editor
Condorman (1981)	911		Bad guys
The Soldier (1982)	930	Ken Wahl	Anti terrorist soldier
48 Hrs. (1982)	Speedster	Eddie Murphy	Foul-mouthed slick convict
Risky Business (1983)	928	Tom Cruise	"daddy's car", smart, sexy, naïve, wealthy, Princeton
Scarface (1983)	928	Al Pacino	Cocaine dealer, unhinged, tough, violent, ruthless, savvy, mob boss
The Big Chill (1983)	911		Yuppies, midlife crisis
Breathless (1983)	356	Richard Gere	Slick Las Vegas hustler with a good side
Class (1983)	911	Rob Lowe	Suave, sophisticated, wealthy, mischievous rebel
Flashdance (1983)	911	"Nick"	Construction company boss
Bachelor Party (1984)	911	Tom Hank's rival	Trust Fund Baby, Military
Sixteen Candles (1984)	944	"Jake Ryan"	High school jock, sensitive
LA Law (1986)	911	"Arnie Becker"	Sleazy, womanizing divorce lawyer
Highlander (1986)	356	Connor MacLeod	Romantic action hero, great powers, strength, immortal
Top Gun (1986)	Speedster	Kelly McGillis	Powerful, smart, pretty, in charge
The Hidden (1987)	928	"Good alien"	FBI Agent
Less Than Zero (1987)	911	Andrew McCarthy	Ivy League preppy, wealthy
Three for the Road (1987)	911	Charlie Sheen	Steals it
No Man's Land (1987)	911	Charlie Sheen	Wealthy, thief, party-guy, icy smooth, risk taker, unhinged
Mystic Pizza (1988)	911	Charles Gordon Windsor	Wealthy, uber-WASP, rebellious law school drop-out, pretty
Bull Durham (1988)	911	Tim Robbins	Star pitcher, sweet but stupid
Tequila Sunrise (1988)	911	"Mac"	Drug dealer, evil, handsome
Dirty Rotten Scoundrels (1988)	911		Wealthy, suave con man
Her Alibi (1989)	356	Tom Selleck	Writer of bad novels looking for love
Three Fugitives (1989)	911	Martin Short	Steals it
Seinfeld (1989–1998)	911	"Jerry"	Wannabe owner, urban, funny, nerdy
The Simpsons (1989–pres)	911	"Krusty the Clown"	Scary, crazy clown, criminal, boozier, gambler, dirtbag
Mr. Destiny (1990)	550	James Belushi	Mid-life crisis, unhappy, powerless man relives youth
Opportunity Knocks (1990)	911	Dana Carvey	Joy ride
Pacific Heights (1990)	911	Michael Keaton	Manipulative, deadly con man
Father of the Bride (1991)	911	Steve Martin	Upper middle class dad in mid-life crisis when daughter leaves nest
Highlander II (1991)	911	Connor MacLeod	Romantic action hero, great powers, strength, immortal
Bill and Ted's Bogus Journey (1991)	911	"Bill and Ted"	Steal it for a joyride
Doc Hollywood (1991)	Speedster	Michael J. Fox	Hot shot big city doctor
Patriot Games (1992)	911	Anne Archer	Doctor, mother
The Player (1992)	911		Trying to pick-up girl
Terminal Bliss (1992)	928	Luke Perry	Affluent, handsome single guy fighting over a girl
Father Hood (1993)	928	Patrick Swayze	Small time criminal
The Specialist (1994)	968	James Woods	Manic villain, psychotic hired gun with a vendetta
Angels in the Outfield (1994)	911	Danny Glover	Baseball manager, skeptic, heart of gold, father
Beverly Hills Cop 3 (1994)	968	Eddie Murphy	Rebel, irreverent scammer
Honor Thy Father and Mother (1994)	911	Erik Menendez	Young, kills parents, buys 911 with insurance money
Nine Months (1995)	911	Hugh Grant	Commitment phobic single psychiatrist becomes a dad
Thinner (1996)	928		Doctor
From Dusk till Dawn (1996)	964	George Clooney	Bank robber on the lam
A Time to Kill (1996)	356	Sandra Bullock	Energetic, ambitious, razor-sharp law student
Kingpin (1996)	993	"Stan"	Bad guy, goon
Kiss The Girls (1997)	911	Morgan Freeman	Detective and author, father, cool and professional, widower
Playing God (1997)	356	David Duchovny	LA surgeon on drugs joins the mob
Batman and Robin (1997)	550	"Batman"	Handsome hero, rich, brave
A Life Less Ordinary (1997)	928		Dentist
Civil Action (1998)	911	John Travolta	Lawyer, desires material success, goes into ruin to help
Dirty Work (1998)			Snooty rich guy
Office Space (1999)	911	"Bill Lumberg"	Suspender wearing yuppie boss
Friends (1999)	996	"Joey"	Single actor who pretends it is his to pick up girls
The Thirteenth Floor (1999)	911	Craig Bierko	Young dashing scientist
Eye of the Beholder (1999)	928	Ashley Judd	Female serial killer
For the Love of the Game (1999)	993	Kevin Costner	40 y/o pitcher in mid-life crisis
Deuce Bigalow, Male Gigolo (1999)	Boxster	"Antoine"	Debonair gigolo
Disney's the Kid (2000)	996	Bruce Willis	High powered image consultant

(continued on next page)

Table 1 (continued)

Movie/television show	Porsche	(Actor or role)	Identity characteristics
American Psycho (2000)	911		Yuppies, Urban, Wealthy
Hollow Man (2000)	996	Kevin Bacon	Brilliant, cocky scientist, insensitive egoist, lack of ethics, narcissistic misogynist
Mission Impossible 2 (2000)	996	Tom Cruise	Heroic, brave, smart, risk taker spy
Space Cowboys (2000)	356	Clint Eastwood	Hot shot test pilot, astronaut
Along Came a Spider (2001)	911	Morgan Freeman	Retired detective/psychologist
Blow (2001)	911	Johnny Depp	Cocaine smuggler, poor roots, wealthy, party-animal, addict
Friends (2001)	911	"Jack Geller"	Dorky middle aged father, lawyer, inappropriate comments, Jewish
Hannibal (2001)	Boxster	Ray Liotta	FBI Agent
James Dean (2001)	550	James Dean	Sexy, dangerous, rebel
Legally Blonde (2001)	Boxster	Reese Witherspoon	Beautiful ditzy blonde sorority girl law student
Life as a House (2001)	911		Rich teenager
Smallville (2001)	996	Lex Luthor	Trust fund, evil criminal mastermind, angry, vengeful, playboy
Die Another Day (2002)	993	"Zao"	Bad guy
Enough (2002)	996		Wealthy wife beater
Anything Else (2003)	356	Woody Allen	Paranoid, odd professor
Intolerable Cruelty (2003)	996	George Clooney	Wealthy, has it all, LA divorce attorney in midlife crisis
Old School (2003)	911	Craig Kilborn	Boyfriend who fools around with the waitress
The Simple Life (2003)	Boxster	Paris Hilton	Bubble headed blonde heiress
Spy Game (2001)	912	Robert Redford	Retiring CIA agent
Barbershop 2: Back in Business (2004)	Boxster	"competitor"	Barbershop owner
Cellular (2004)	Cayenne	Kim Basinger	High school biology teacher
Cellular (2004)	911		Obnoxious, smarmy lawyer
In Good Company (2004)		Topher Grace "Carter"	Young, business school prodigy, dumped by his wife
Be Cool (2005)	911	Harvey Keitel	Sleazy record label executive
Bewitched (2005)	996	Will Ferrell	Self-absorbed actor
Just Friends (2005)	911	Ryan Reynolds	Rich, shy, good looking music executive, smooth talking lady killer
The Transporter 2 (2005)	Cayenne		"bad guy"
Big Momma's House 2 (2006)	911	Martin Lawrence	Wife pressures To give up 911 for SUV, cross dressing FBI agent
The Sopranos (2006)	Cayenne	"Carmella"	Mob boss' wife, soccer mom, suburban, Italian
The Sopranos (2006)	Boxster	"Rosalie"	Mobster's wife, newly single, Italian, suburban
Cars (2006)	996	"Sally Carrera"	Porsche as anthropomorphized woman, lawyer, rebel's love interest

was used to reconstruct a longitudinal netnography designed to capture the existing consumers' response to the SUV. The four-year longitudinal design allowed for the capture of consumers' responses in real time, rather than retrospective reflection, and permitted the observation of both the immediate and the longer term responses. The tenets of netnographic community selection (Kozinets, 2002) were used to identify a specific Porsche online community for study. Rennlist, an international community of Porsche enthusiasts, was chosen because it is the largest automotive special interest website on the internet, enjoying 65,000 subscribers at the time of this study. Rennlist features a large number of members who post to the consumer-to-consumer web forums, and it consists of a diverse group of posters including current and prospective Porsche owners from 29 countries. At the time of this study, over 36,000 participants were talking with each other on the Rennlist web forums, while their conversations were being read by an estimated 200,000 additional people.

Car brands often elicit strong, active brand community participation among their consumers (Algesheimer, Dholakia, & Herrmann, 2005). Rennlist is a brand community that exhibits the three markers of brand community (Muniz & O'Guinn, 2001). First, the Rennlist community exhibits a consciousness of kind. Strong ties exist among the members who experience a group identity; many have participated in the community for many years and communicate with each other daily. Second, the Rennlist community has numerous rituals and traditions that include greeting rituals, norms that govern online conversations and racing etiquette, status monikers, traditional ride events, clubs consisting of members who share a particular interest, and tangible markers such as decals and t-shirts. Finally, the members of the Rennlist community have a shared sense of moral responsibility toward their fellow community members and toward the community itself. Community members log on daily to ask for purchase or technical advice but also to discuss how to navigate the social challenges of owning a Porsche.

I unobtrusively observed the conversations on the Rennlist web forums as a nonparticipating observer. Fifty-five months of historical data spanning from May 2001 through November 2005 and consisting

of 181,000 conversations (threads) were manually combed through and read during a five-month netnographic immersion in the archives. Field notes were written throughout to capture any emerging insights based on the identification of recurrent behaviors across people. Emerging grounded theory was tested by returning to the data to scrutinize constructs and their relationships, to unearth counterexamples, and to affirm, challenge, elaborate, and refine the conceptual model (Glaser & Strauss, 1967). The data were reread, and conceptual constructs and relationships were iteratively adjusted until sufficient interpretative convergence was achieved. Following the conclusion of the analysis, I purchased a Porsche 911, participated in dealer and driver education events with other owners, and began conversing on Rennlist to add participant-observer ethnographic data to the analysis, following the participant observation method pursued by Muniz and Schau (2005). Finally, I conducted five three-hour member check interviews with Porsche owners to confirm and refine my understanding of the online conversations.

4. Results

4.1. Porsche as a marker of masculinity

My cultural analysis of the brand yielded shared identity meanings that are evident across all of the characters driving Porsche vehicles in American movies and television programs. Porsche drivers are overwhelmingly male: 91% of the characters portrayed were men. Porsche helps men express their masculinity by tapping into two strains of masculinity that are present in contemporary culture and summarized by Holt and Thompson (2004): the "Breadwinner" and the "Rebel." Contemporary men often use their consumption practices to tack between these two myths to shape their masculinity into a new gender ideology that exhibits a combination of the two, the man-of-action hero. Breadwinner masculinity is characterized by a man who "pursues organization success by following rules, [and who is] responsible, respectable, rational, reserved, [a] community pillar, safe," while rebel masculinity is characterized by a man who "pursues

autonomy by defying institutional rules, [and who is] creative, confident, self-directed, potent, youthful, dangerous” (Holt & Thompson, 2004: 437). The Porsche brand encompasses many of the expectations associated with masculinity that underpin the breadwinner and the rebel myths, such as “No Sissy Stuff” (anti-feminine), “The Big Wheel” (wealth and power), “The Sturdy Oak” (toughness and dependability), and “Give ‘Em Hell” (aggression and rebellion) suggested by Brannon (1976), the “Playboy” or “Macho Man” suggested by Lindsey (1997) and Osgerby (2001), and the “Peter Pan” (childlike and irresponsible) summarized by Register (2001).

Wealthy, professional white collar men drive Porsche sports cars. These men are doctors, lawyers, scientists, and businessmen, living successful breadwinner lives. Their Porsche sports cars are external markers of their success and wealth. A darker side to Porsche is also evident that helps the brand to express rebel masculinity. Villains, such as cocaine smugglers, hustlers, and criminals drive Porsche sports cars, giving the brand a risky, dangerous edge. These Porsche men are cocky, irreverent, rebellious, risk-seeking loners who buck the traditional establishment. Tough “good guys” drive Porsche sports cars, including detectives, military men, CIA operatives, and spies. Porsche men are sexy and sexual, both in appealing and not so appealing ways, as adulterers or womanizers. These men are often egotistical, narcissistic, or spoiled brats and coping with midlife crises during which they engage in irresponsible behavior. Movies illustrate the symbolic value of a Porsche as an antidote for aging and the resolution of mid-life crises. They also use it as a symbol for the loss of manhood associated with marriage and family in which characters feel pressured to give up their Porsche sports car for a more sensible family car.

I compared the findings of the cultural analysis with my netnographic analysis of the brand community to see if the lived experiences of the consumers were consistent with the mass mediated brand meanings surrounding masculinity and to understand how the identity meanings of Porsche contained in the mass culture discourse are interpreted by men in everyday consumption practice, following Holt and Thompson (2004). The brand community frequently engages with mass culture discourses in their communal discussions of their brand, creating a discursive field fueled by both the mass mediated meaning and their own consumption situated personalized meanings. In conversations, the movies that contain Porsche cars are dissected, and media-incited stereotypes are identified and then grounded by personal stories.

The brand community revels in the masculine exclusivity of Porsche, and masculine ideologies are often at the crux of the consumers' stories about their ownership experience. The members frequently remind each other that 85% of Porsche owners are men. To the members of the brand community, buying a Porsche is often seen as an assertion of one's manhood, whether it is the first purchase of a used Porsche following an adolescence spent in a room filled with Porsche memorabilia or whether it is stubbornly holding onto a cherished Porsche in the face of spousal disapproval. Members of the brand community struggle against giving up their Porsche cars when they become fathers, and they mourn the cars that they have sold to fulfill family obligations. The stereotype of a Porsche as an antidote to a man's midlife crisis is openly acknowledged, and the brand community abashedly accepts it as accurate, with many owners citing a midlife crisis as the impetus for their purchase. Porsche cars are powerful antidotes to the anxieties about aging and the impending decrease in virility that characterize many midlife crises (Aldwin & Levenson, 2001) because they allow their owners to regress back to an earlier age in which they enjoyed few responsibilities and entanglements and when they were in their sexual prime.

Porsche cars are viewed by many in the community as tools to attract women. Throughout their conversations, sexual meanings are introduced and debated. Some members wear these meanings proudly, while others are somewhat embarrassed by them. The comments below capture owners' perceptions of the transformative sexual

power of their cars. Women's responses to their cars bolster their masculinity and allow them to engage in fantasy play.

Earlier this week I took whifey for a spin in the [Porsche] 930 and whilst sitting at a traffic light she suddenly exploded...“Them bitches!” she said, pointing at the two hotties in the Honda next to us checking out the Porsche and making eyes at me... Hell, I didn't even notice them before. Now, I'm not a man who screws around. Quite happily married for 17 years now. But I must admit, getting the old ego stroked at intersections reminds me of high school and kinda makes me feel like a real stud...Oh shit, is this what they call a “midlife crisis”? (Pierre Martins)

There's super hot women everywhere, ignoring us. Keep in mind, I don't exactly fit in with the more well dressed clientele at this establishment as I am mostly very happy in a nice t-shirt and a pair of jeans. Anyway, tons of hotties, no love (and in some cases a bit of attitude and contempt) from any of them, until we decided to leave. We walk outside and head across the street to my [Porsche] 996. When it is apparent as to which car we are going to, I hear, ‘Mr. bald guy, where are you going, come back’ from a group of about 10 absolutely drop dead beautiful, tightly clothed, amazingly sexy women. These very same woman only moments before were not paying us any attention. (mastermind)

Mastermind's story demonstrates the transformation of an emasculated man who is failing to keep up with the men who surround him due to his attire and his balding pate. His Porsche becomes a magical transport, bringing him back into the game and enabling him to capture the attention of women.

A Porsche's technical performance, including its power, its speed, and its handling, is a source of pride for Porsche owners. The brand community revels in the fact that driving a Porsche requires a higher level of skill and that women (and lesser men) have difficulty in driving them. This attitude is evidenced in the following post that argues that only “real men” can handle the car. Driving a Porsche involves the physical mastery of the machine, which requires its drivers to be strong, powerful, and mechanically skilled, traits strongly associated with the cultural definitions of masculinity (Mishkind, Rodin, Silberstein, & Moore-Striegel, 1987).

Man, that's basically what Porsche is all about! Porsches & especially the early ones were made for REAL drivers, not every ‘average Joe’ out there. There are plenty of cars that are easy & boring to drive and requires almost no driving skills at all. So one who can't handle Porsche, can get a Honda or something. (Flying Finn)

Hence, prior to the launch of the SUV, in the media and in the situated use in the lives of consumers, the Porsche brand serves as a strong marker of masculinity for its owners.

4.2. The gender contamination of the Porsche Cayenne SUV

Merely 9% of the movies and television programs that I analyzed in the cultural analysis featured female Porsche drivers. Two of the women drove the Porsche Cayenne SUV. Carmella in *The Sopranos* is a middle aged, suburban housewife married to a mob boss, while Kim Basinger plays a middle aged teacher who is kidnapped and fights to save her family in *Cellular*. These two roles suggest that the SUV is bringing new identity meanings to the brand, which include middle aged, suburban motherhood, indicating that the Porsche brand might be becoming gender contaminated.

To confirm that the Porsche Cayenne SUV brought new gender identity meanings to the Porsche brand, I used a one-way between-subjects multivariate analysis of variance (MANOVA) to analyze the data from the brand identity meaning elicitation experiment, using all of the 28

items as dependent variables. The descriptive statistics for each of the 28 items by condition are contained in Table 2. A multivariate test of the full model showed that these 28 dependent variables were significantly affected by the experimental condition (Wilks' $\lambda = .002$, $F(56, 160) = 2.194$, $p < .001$). While Porsche sports cars and the Porsche Cayenne SUV share some identity meanings, the tests of between-subject effects showed that they differ on eleven, including seven that are closely tied to sex or gender identity (Male/Female, Masculine/Feminine, Soccer Mom, Playboy) or that are correlated with gender identity based on commonly accepted gender stereotypes, (Dangerous/Cautious, Reckless/Safe, Car Lover), (Bem, 1974; Edelbrock & Sugawara, 1978; Spence & Helmreich, 1978). Porsche sports cars owners are perceived to be more male, more masculine, more like a playboy, more dangerous, more reckless and more of a car lover than the Porsche Cayenne SUV owners, who are perceived to be more female, more feminine, more like a soccer mom, more cautious, and more safe. The absence of differences for the remaining items indicates that some of Porsche's identity meanings, particularly those related to economic status, self-esteem, and social display behaviors, remain intact with the SUV launch.

Consistent with the findings suggested by the cultural analysis and the experiment, my analysis of the netnographic data from the Porsche brand community indicates that the launch of the Porsche Cayenne contaminated Porsche as a marker of masculinity and threatened the masculine gender display of the existing Porsche owners. Across the myriad of conversations in my dataset, I uncovered a dominant theme that discussed the alternative gender identity meanings brought by the Porsche Cayenne SUV, their threat to the masculine meanings previously associated with Porsche, and their stigmatizing impact on the members of the brand community. Many of the existing owners lamented that the Porsche Cayenne SUV not only feminized the Porsche brand but also introduced alternative, subordinate versions of masculinity to it. The brand community's analysis expresses alarm over the femininity of the brand extension.

Table 2
Porsche identity meanings (sports cars vs. SUV).

	Sports car mean ^a	Sports car SD	SUV mean ^a	SUV SD	Sig. ^b
Soccer mom	6.41	.798	3.88	1.822	***
Playboy	2.86	1.378	4.97	1.507	***
Car lover	2.51	1.387	3.75	1.785	**
Yuppie	2.51	1.070	2.24	1.208	
Status oriented	1.81	.995	1.69	.739	
Male/female	2.24	.830	3.71	1.404	**
Young/old	4.35	.949	4.56	1.106	
Single/married	3.35	1.207	5.09	1.379	**
Urban/suburban	3.43	1.642	4.88	1.533	**
Poor/rich	6.49	.559	6.51	.633	
Has kids/has no kids	5.05	1.201	3.18	1.642	**
Wants to fit in/wants to stand out	5.51	1.346	5.34	1.223	
Hip/mainstream	3.76	1.722	3.29	1.169	
Dangerous/cautious	3.30	1.024	4.32	1.364	**
Exciting/boring	2.97	1.142	3.50	.862	
Fun loving/serious	3.05	1.290	3.97	1.141	**
Discriminating tastes/follows the crowd	3.68	1.811	3.41	1.258	
Cool/uncool	3.16	1.259	3.29	1.142	
Stylish/unstylish	2.70	1.222	2.74	.931	
Arrogant/humble	1.78	.821	2.24	.955	†
Showy/modest	1.76	.683	1.94	.776	
Snobby/down to earth	2.38	.953	2.53	.961	
Insecure/secure	3.00	1.291	3.24	1.046	
Practical/impractical	5.41	1.066	4.96	1.170	
Inferiority/superiority complex	3.84	1.500	4.50	1.022	
Follower/leader	4.22	1.357	4.50	.929	
Masculine/feminine	2.68	.944	3.85	1.395	**
Reckless/safe	3.59	.985	4.50	1.080	**

^a For first five single items, 7-point Likert scale, 1 anchors "agree" and 7 anchors "disagree". For all remaining items, 7-point scale, 1 anchors first trait of pair and 7 anchors second trait of pair.

^b † = $p < .10$, * = $p < .05$, ** = $p < .01$, and *** = $p < .001$.

I am actually excited about seeing them [the Porsche Cayenne SUV] driving around on the roads, but I'm not excited at all about seeing who's driving them. Hopefully I will see a competent-looking driver, but I know I'll see a soccer mom like I see in every [Hummer] H2 around here. It just gives me a heeb. Like this morning, I was behind a BEAUTIFUL brand new [Porsche] 911 turbo for like 10 minutes! I flipped my shit and couldn't take my eyes off it. Then I passed by at a light when it turned, only to find a 50 year old-ish looking woman with poofy fake looking hair driving it... I had to hold back the tears. Anyone else feel this way when they see out-of-place Porsche drivers? Like people you KNOW right when you look at em — that they don't give a shit about having the privilege to drive a precision engineered German sports car!!! (TarHeel 944S)

You guys forget that you have the wrong hormones flowing through your veins to understand why Porsche is putting out this SUV. My wife would snatch one up in a heartbeat. Someone mentioned the worst scenario would be soccer moms driving these. Well, get ready to meet your nightmare. It'll be sitting at a stop light near you. (Bart)

I heard a rumor that Porsche was devoting their entire racing budget to the Cayenne Challenge, an event that pits homemakers against each other in a challenging obstacle course. ...events include: 1000 metre grocery dash. Drivers launch from a standing start and drive furiously to a simulated shopping center where 4 bags of groceries are loaded before the driver hurtles their 2+ ton vehicle back to the start/finish line... Multitasking behind the wheel... Drivers negotiate a difficult city street simulation while talking on a cell phone, cradling a Grande Non-Fat, No-Whip Mocha in their lap, and applying mascara or lipstick. (H20NOO)

Porsche's marketing efforts confirm the existing owners' suspicions that the Porsche Cayenne SUV is targeted toward women. Many of the early photographs released by PAG depict women drivers, local Porsche dealerships advertise special "soccer mom promotions," and PAG sponsors women's professional tennis. These marketing efforts further the feminization of the brand and causes consternation among the Porsche men.

They say that they are aiming this at 42 to 47 yr old males with porsches...but, all the photos ive seen have girls driving it and that putz shwab [President of Porsche North America, Fred Schwab] says that its great for the alpha female/wife. (RobertG)

It is not merely the introduction of women to the brand that alarms the existing owners; it is that Porsche has introduced its first non-sports car with the introduction of the SUV. SUV's are perceived by the brand community as "practical vehicles" that are popular with mainstream consumers, while Porsche sports cars are valued for the fact that they are fun, frivolous, and rare. The introduction of the SUV weakens the association between the brand and its masculine sports car heritage. Porsche owners begin to fear that the launch of the Porsche Cayenne SUV opens the door for future non-sports car models from Porsche that will push it into even more feminine categories, such as minivans or station wagons, which open the brand to a broader audience, thereby diminishing its mystique.

If this trend keeps up — Porsche will be building station wagons to compete with the Subaru Outback and then Minivans to compete with the Chrysler. (DoubleNutz)

Yeah, I can't wait for the day when Porsche offer a car for each group of buyer. A van for the soccer mom, a Lexus like porsche sedan for those who prefer comfort over performance, a porsche hatchback for the younger buyers who can't pay a lot. Yeah, everybody's driving a porsche and they are all happy and some

of them will one day drive a [Porsche] 911...but wait, what does a 911 mean to them anyway? We are all driving porsches, and my porsche van is better than your 9 what? So much for the porsche mystique. (Cloud964)

Finally, while some SUV brands, such as Hummer and Jeep, function as masculine markers and convey their masculinity with off-road adventure mythology and an aggressive physical design, others are associated with more feminine imagery. The brand community largely finds the Porsche SUV to be less masculine than the Hummer, Jeep, and Range Rover SUVs, and labels it as more reminiscent of a station wagon or a minivan, both of which are vehicles that are associated with women. In the following posts, the brand community members connect competitive SUVs with masculine themes (Lamborghini = sex, Hummer = military tanks, Suburban = cowboy) but are unable to do the same for the Porsche SUV.

A truck/SUV should look like a truck—large in dimensions and boxy, with a strong upright grille—lots of right angles. Rugged... I identify with SUV's like the Suburban (we used to call them Cowboy Cadillacs)... Also, the Cayenne looks very feminine to my eyes, which doesn't jive with my sense of a traditional, rugged SUV. (Anir)

Mr. Lamborghini said to his engineers... I want you to build a car that when I say to my wife 'I'm going out to buy cigarettes', is so good looking that first good looking lady will come with me to the hotel, and is so fast when I'll come back, my wife says: 'that was fast honey!'... Little different than what boys at [Porsche] told their designers...we want to have a car, that...every soccer mom likes, but 25 year old hotties couldn't care less and has so much cargo space that we can fit 30 grocery bags easily. (Flying Finn)

Even though I personally do not like the Hummer, I believe it is selling well because of its tough, masculine image. It appeals to those who want the biggest, baddest, Schwartznegger-ish truck on the planet. OTOH, the Cayenne is actually a bit feminine in its lines. It looks more like a minivan or tall station wagon than a traditional truck. (Anir)

Many of the brand community members fret that the Cayenne is feminine, citing features of the vehicle that suggest that the SUV was designed for women: its automatic tiptronic transmission, its cupholders, and its feminine design. The automatic transmission obliterates the physical challenge of mastering Porsche's difficult handling, while the cupholders add unnecessary weight to the vehicle, heretical in a race car. Both of these features decrease the product's masculinity quotient by distancing the SUV from Porsche's sports cars, as evidenced in the following brand community conversation. Note how the SUV is associated with women, metrosexuals, and men "without balls," distancing the SUV drivers from masculinity narratives. Porsche's executives are feminized and accused of eating and dressing in unmanly ways:

On the subject of when did carmakers lose their balls... When the average male became a metrosexual and lost his. It is true... Men are no longer men though. They want powered cup holders, and soft touch interiors so they don't damage their manicured nails... Then to top it off, German car makers start acting like Asian car makers. They now wear suits fit for Milan while eating sushi for lunch. And this is supposed to be the Porsche I looked forward to when I was a kid? I want the company I worshiped when young but was too young to drive. The whole situation makes me sick. AHHH. That's it, I am going to go take my uncivilized, no-sissy-need-apply, non-muffled [Porsche] 911 out for a wild ride and try to forget the whole thing... Little did I know then that most cars today would be built for sissy wimps with no taste, driving skill and automotive historical knowledge by companies lacking the required cojones to stick to their original ideals. It is sad. In my opinion, cupholder doesn't belong in a Porsche (or any sports car for

that matter), nor does tiptronic [automatic transmission] etc.... (Ed Bighi)

However, all that sort of things seem now almost fine, when I'm comparing them to a Cayenne. You're absolutely right on that one... The day they started rolling Porsches off the line with Tiptronic and cupholders was a sad day indeed... It pains me to see what was one a no nonsense pure race car now plagued with useless extra weight and soft suspensions to make that trip to the grocery store more comfy. (Flying Finn)

And a 6 speed [manual transmission]? You know, soccer moms don't want to shift — it may interfere with their quality cell phone time :rolleyes: (mpm '95 C4)

The introduction of the Porsche Cayenne SUV threatens the masculine identity of the brand's users. The owners voice their concerns that the buyers of the SUV are incongruent with their desired masculine identity. The excerpts from the brand community conversations below are indicative of the negative emotional response that this incongruence elicits and are indicative of the out-of-face emotional disturbance that the identity threat brings. The owners experience the SUV as a personal affront, a "slap in the face" or an "ugly sister" that reflects badly on them:

And it is impossible for me to dispassionately talk about this slap-in-the-face soccer-mom-tank-barge from the accountants who now run Porsche. To find that Porsche is now selling SUV's, and soon pick-ups, toothbrushes, and maybe perfume, is atrocious. They have destroyed the brand and killed its mystique. My days of reading the race results from Le Mans to figure out how many of the top positions were Porsches is long dead — and the accountants and marketers at Porsche are dancing on the grave, while they try to figure out how to make more money from the brand name. I'm sick... (mike_la_jolla)

The Cayenne remains the 'ugly sister', a necessary blemish on, an up to now, untarnished marque. (Robbo 66)

While research has suggested that physical damage to a man's car can represent castration (Belk, 2004), the Porsche brand community shows that symbolic damage to a man's car brand can be just as painful.

4.3. Defending masculinity markers through collective identity work

In the sections below, I describe the collective face-saving identity work that the brand community engages in as a defensive justifying practice (Schau, Muniz, & Arnould, 2009) to alleviate the gender identity crisis brought on by the SUV. This identity work involves attaching derogatory gender stereotypes to SUV owners that psychologically and socially establish an ingroup/outgroup. This behavior is consistent with social psychological research on stereotyping, which shows that group threat leads to the stereotyping of others and a prejudicial affect toward them. Stereotyping places others into categories, and this categorization leads to the construction of boundaries among groups and the creation of ingroup/outgroup social structures (Tajfel & Turner, 1979) in which people surround themselves with others who resemble them and distance themselves from those who do not as a way of declaring who one is (and who one is not).

4.3.1. Collective gender stereotyping

In their online conversations, the brand community members stereotype Porsche Cayenne SUV owners, claiming that the product is purchased by people who are very different from the existing owners, specifically "soccer moms" who are looking for a trendy SUV to avoid driving a minivan to the grocery store, shopping mall, and school playgrounds, "poseurs" who are interested in obtaining the image of a Porsche but who are not true car enthusiasts and cannot properly handle

the cars, and “yuppies” who are merely seeking a status symbol. The gender significance of each of these three stereotypes is discussed below.

As observed by [Martin, Schouten, and McAlexander \(2006\)](#) in their study of female Harley-Davidson owners, women who purchase symbols of masculinity engage with and co-opt masculinity discourses through their consumption of these products. Through the gender stereotyping that links the Porsche Cayenne SUV to a derisive soccer mom stereotype, the existing Porsche owners block this transfer of masculinity to the women who buy the SUV by supplanting positive masculine associations with negative feminine associations, thereby making the product less attractive to women for gender experimentation. At the same time, the linkage of the SUV to a feminine ideology further diminishes its attractiveness to men because it strips the product of its masculinity, thereby limiting the product's appeal and its lifespan in the marketplace. The following post is an example of the usage of the “soccer mom” stereotype.

... My GOD say it ain't so! I keep telling myself that if I wish and hope and pray hard enough... that it won't happen. That this SUV thing is all just a bad dream.... And you were there, Auntie Lane, and Uncle Killporsche... That perhaps this is all just an elaborate hoax and coverup for what what is really going to be the greatest Porsche since the [Porsche] 956. That maybe Porsche Marketing will point at everyone and laugh saying, C'mon... You *really* believed all that CRAP about SUVs?! This is Porsche for cry'n out loud. We're proud Germans! We don't make jokes! We make race bread and race WINNING sports cars! NOT MINI Vans! I can just see it know... Some rich Soccer Mom driving the damn thing to pick up her kids with a bumper sticker that reads, Proud parent of honor student and a Baby on Board sticker next to the Barney stick on sunshade with a baby seat in back... NO! WAIT! The ULTIMATE killjoy! Porsche adds a fold down babyseat standard in each one! ...Oh the humanity! ...I wonder how many cup holders it will have??? Just shoot me now! (Doc)

The “soccer mom” stereotype gains cultural resonance from its connections to the cultural discourses surrounding the identity meanings attached to SUV owners. The *New York Times* columnist [Bradsher \(2002\)](#) connects SUVs to an emerging social group defined as “soccer moms” in the cultural vernacular, calling them the vehicle of choice for women who are trying to escape the stigma of driving a minivan. This description, ironically, transfers the negative associations that the women were trying to avoid in the minivan category to the SUV category. “Soccer mom” is a pejorative term for third wave or post-feminist, upper class motherhood and homemaking. A soccer mom is an affluent homemaker, often very highly educated, who has left behind a successful professional career to voluntarily stay home and take care of her children. The soccer mom stereotype hearkens back to the housewife and Stepford Wife stereotypes berated by second wave feminists such as Betty [Friedan \(1963\)](#), who depicted the home as a prison in which women were subjugated to servitude to meet their family's needs and who depicted the housewife as a passive, dehumanized robot. Updated in contemporary television shows such as *Desperate Housewives*, today's soccer moms are portrayed as boring, bored, frustrated, and depressed, with no identity of their own and with few responsibilities or achievements outside of those of their family.

The soccer mom ideology emerged in American culture during third stage feminism, a movement characterized by [Faludi \(1992\)](#) as a backlash against the definitions of success put forth by the second stage feminists. “Opting out” of the public sphere and an identity built around professional success, soccer moms returned to the home and embraced voluntary domesticity and the traditional roles of wife and mother, encouraged by alternative versions of femininity offered by media celebrities such as Martha Stewart and Nigella Lawson who celebrated women's roles in the private sphere ([Brunsdon, 2006](#)). Given that these soccer moms had grown up during three decades of feminist

critique against the traditional definitions of femininity and the subjugation of women in the home, opting out was often accompanied by strong feelings of guilt and regret about giving up their hard earned professional identities, of accepting less than their mothers, and of surrendering the ground won by second wave feminists ([Hollows, 2006](#)).

The attachment of the soccer mom stereotype to the Porsche Cayenne SUV associates the vehicle not only with femininity but with a particular feminine ideology that is not attractive to men or women. The women who purchase the SUV must contend with being labeled a “soccer mom,” a stereotype that prevents them from gaining access to the masculine meanings that are traditionally associated with Porsche. Through the use of the “soccer mom” stereotype, the existing Porsche owners relegate the Porsche Cayenne SUV owners to the bottom of a gender power structure. By linking the product to negative conceptions of domesticity and motherhood that hearken back to an era when women had significantly less power and were relegated to the private, rather than the public sphere, the existing Porsche owners increase the power distance between the Porsche sports cars and the SUV and, hence, between themselves and the Porsche Cayenne SUV owners.

The “poseurs” stereotype has existed in the Porsche brand community since its inception. Throughout history, following the launch of controversial Porsche vehicles, the brand community has engaged in debates in which the members argue over whether the owners that the new product brings to the brand are “real” Porsche men or mere poseurs. Brand community members depict the “poseurs” as deviant from the traditional definitions of masculinity and emasculate them by referring to their lack of understanding of the technical workings of the car, their inability and/or unwillingness to push the car to its limits, or their lack of appreciation for the brand's illustrious racing heritage. It has been shown that automobiles can be regarded as sacred objects by their devotees ([Belk, Wallendorf, & Sherry, 1989](#)), with rituals devoted to caring for them, to showing them off to others, and to driving them in a manner deemed appropriate by the brand's evangelists ([Belk, 2004](#)). As Leigh, Peters, and Shelton found in their study of MG owners (2006), being accepted as an authentic member of a brand community requires much more than just buying the brand; it requires driving (and respecting) the brand in the appropriate way. Porsche owners adhere to similar rituals and demean those who do not follow them. SUV owners are considered inauthentic: they do not drive in the appropriate manner, driving too slowly or carefully; they do not care for their vehicle in a respectful manner, letting it get dirty or parking it too close to other cars; and they do not respect the heritage of the brand and its racing roots. The post below is an example of the “poseurs” stereotype in the brand community conversations.

That's why they're making Cayenne... There are plenty of people (with money) who only want to drive Porsche because there is a badge on the hood. These people would be driving happily Honda Civic's w/ the Porsche badge & hefty price. They don't care/know what good handling is, why ignition key is on left, what's so great about going over 160 and hearing that wonderful flat six ‘singing’ behind you etc. Only thing they care is that name. They're cruising around 20 mph and that's it for them. Irony is that they want to drive Porsche because of that name, mystic etc. that has come from Porsche being true sportscar company, winning LeMans etc. Now, making this change (to a wrong direction), that mystic, name that they want to show off to their buddies, might not be like that in future. It soon might be just another car company. To many people, I'm sure, it's just an transportation to go from A to B & to show it off, but for me, it's not just a car, and that's why this bothers me. (Flying Finn)

The poseurs' stereotype indicates that one cannot merely buy masculinity through the purchase of a Porsche; rather, to “grab the phallus” ([Thompson & Holt, 2004](#)), one must embody the masculine ideals of the

brand. The decision of whether one is worthy of Porsche's gender identity meanings is adjudicated by the members of the Porsche brand community, who designate which owners belong in the group and which do not. Although one can aspire to masculinity via the purchase of a Porsche, it is only through acceptance by the brand community that one rises above the rank of poseur (Leigh, Peters, & Shelton, 2006). Through brand community discussions that label the SUV owners as poseurs, the Porsche sports car owners further disassociate themselves from them.

The “yuppies” stereotype also has subcultural resonance in the Porsche brand community because it is a stigmatized identity that has been linked with the brand since the 1980s. During the 1980s, Porsche became the car of choice for “yuppies”: young, upwardly mobile professionals. It is interesting to notice in the post below how the “yuppie” is depicted as deviant from the traditional definitions of masculinity and feminized by referencing the yuppies' preoccupation with fashion and taste for feminine beverages.

The Cayenne started life a few years ago with 450 BHP from its 4.7 litre V8.... And what do they do with this modern masterpiece of engineering? They put the bloody thing in a glorified tractor. 90% of which are used to convey their Armani-suited owners to shopping malls to order cafes **&^+#\$! latte or **\$+ !* chardonnay or very occasionally some seriously rough stuff on the driveway to the + **^%!\ golf club! AAARRGGHH. Words fail me! Oh life! Deep drives thy sting... This thing makes a joke of us. (ColinB)

While the “yuppie” stereotype contains breadwinner masculinity, as noted by the upper class references contained in above post (Armani, country club), it is deficient in rebel masculinity, leaving the men who purchase the Porsche Cayenne SUV lacking the blend necessary to achieve hegemonic masculinity through Porsche ownership.

Through stereotyping, the members of the Porsche brand community thwart the SUV owners' efforts to “grab the phallus.” Both men and women who purchase the SUV are labeled with stereotypes that distance them from the existing sports car owners, designating them as “the other.” These stereotypes are summarized in the following post that uses humor to paint SUV owners as lacking in masculinity. Specifically, Cayenne owners are linked to such feminine consumption practices as wearing fashionable and precious clothing, having a manicure, drinking designer coffees, embracing feng-shui design, and attending a spa.

101 Projects for Your Cayenne... 1. Adding air to the tires on your own. Cost: \$27 (\$5 tip to gas station attendant to instruct use of air hose; \$20 dry cleaning for rustic-looking wool gabardine pants; \$2 for latex exam gloves to protect manicure). 2. Getting Coffee While Someone Else Changes Your Oil. Cost \$125 (Visit to doctor's office to ensure you are OK after having learning that you consumed non-designer brand of coffee in the waiting room = \$120, Bottle of Pepto Bismol = \$5). 3. Modifying Cup Holder to Accommodate Mega Grande Latte. Cost = \$700 (Porsche Upgrade Coffee Holder Kit = \$300, Custom fitted overalls with embroidered Porsche crest = \$200; Neiman-Marcus signature screwdriver set = \$100; Massage Therapist to massage aching limp wrist = \$100). 4. Installing Floor Mats. Cost = \$450 (Porsche Factory Mats \$200; Feng-Shui Consultant to assist with color choice and alignment = \$250). 6. Upgrading GPS Software: Cost = \$600 (Worldwide Starbuck's locations Software = \$120; Spa Locator Software = \$200; Polo Club Registry Software = \$100). 7. Installing Lacrosse Stick Holder: Cost = \$675 (Porsche Techquipment Lacrosse Stick Holder Kit = \$500, Neiman Marcus Signature Screwdriver Set (exclude if already purchased for cup holder project) = \$100; Color coordinated calfskin mechanic's gloves = \$75). (Rich911E, Tumalo)

Psychologically constructing a barrier between themselves and the women (and feminized men) who join the brand community through the purchase of an SUV, the existing Porsche owners resolve

the identity dissonance associated with the SUV by viewing themselves as very different from the new Porsche owners who do not live up to their version of masculinity. This separation allows them to psychologically renew their commitment to the Porsche brand as a masculine identity marker without accepting its dilution. Because the stereotyping is a communal practice that is achieved through public conversations and is thus not confined to the minds of individual consumers, its inculcation has social effects. The stereotyping clearly specifies the characteristics and practices that define a real Porsche man, establishing norms of behavior for the members of the brand community. Through these acts, the meanings associated with the Porsche Cayenne SUV that challenge the traditional definitions of masculinity are suppressed and contained.

In summary, the Porsche owners' gender stereotyping of the SUV owners stratifies the Porsche brand community along gender lines; the existing Porsche sports car owners populate the ingroup and enjoy access to Porsche's masculine identity meanings, while the Porsche Cayenne SUV owners and the feminine identity meanings that are attached to them populate the outgroup. Symbolically, the Porsche sports car owners construct a gated community around themselves where the gates that mark the boundary between them and the SUV owners impede the transfer of masculine identity meanings from the Porsche sports cars to the Porsche SUV and, more importantly, impede the undesirable transfer of feminine identity meanings from the Porsche SUV to the Porsche sports cars. Importantly, the ingroup is sharply defined by and dedicated to hegemonic masculinity, while the outgroup is defined by femininity and subordinate masculinities. Hence, Porsche's masculine meanings are protected from dilution through the incursion of undesirable others by acts of containment; through stereotyping, Porsche owners psychologically and socially keep the masculine identity meanings in and the feminine meanings out. Through their actions, the Porsche owners thwart the desire of the firm to open the brand to women, reverse the evolution of the brand's gender identity meanings, and reinstate Porsche as a masculine identity marker. The angry backlash among the existing customers of the brand more firmly defines Porsche as a symbol of masculinity and strengthens the ties between “real men” and the brand.

Despite the fact that brand communities are often conceptualized as egalitarian, populist, and operating outside of the constraints of the external culture's status system (Cova & Cova, 2002), most brand communities exhibit well-defined and rigid status hierarchies that reflect the members' different levels of adherence to the ethos of the community (Schouten & McAlexander, 1995). The members earn status through their participation within the group, their level of ownership, their idiosyncratic knowledge and experience with the brand or the community, and their allegiances with status-endowed others. Researchers have conceptualized this status structure as a series of concentric circles, at the center of which are the “hard-core” consumers (Fox, 1987). It is these hard-core consumers who play the major role in creating and arbitrating brand meaning (Fox, 1987; Holt, 2004; Schouten & McAlexander, 1995). By collectively responding to the identity threat of the Cayenne, the existing Porsche owners leverage the status system of their brand community and create new status distinctions that place Cayenne owners at the bottom of the hierarchy. Social stratification limits the contamination of the Porsche brand by reinforcing gender distinctions and boundaries and circumscribing the Porsche Cayenne SUV to contain its feminizing influence.

The emergence of a social hierarchy strengthens the ties among the privileged members (sports car owners) and perpetuates their own interpretations of the brand's meaning, thereby increasing their commitment to the community and facilitating the identity projects that they are pursuing through use of the brand. Concurrently, the ingroup/outgroup social structures increase the social distance among the member subgroups, as the less privileged groups (Cayenne owners) are ostracized, precluded from participation in rituals and practices, and denied access to the brand meanings that they need for their own

identity work. Hence, the less privileged members are not able to derive social benefits from their brand ownership, losing the communal and identity benefits of being part of a brand community.

What makes the Porsche activity different from other settings in which car club participants exclude replicas or reproduction cars from participating in their activities (Belk, 2004) is that the Porsche SUV is an authentic Porsche. As Leigh, Peters, and Shelton remind us, “When brand communities and subcultures are operative in a brand’s ‘meaning’ ecology, managers no longer solely own the brand, its associations, or the right to position it for strictly commercial purposes.” (2006: 492). Now, it is the Porsche brand community that wields control.

4.3.2. Trying to fit in through hyper-masculinity

Some men in the brand community purchase the Porsche Cayenne SUV, and the negative stereotyping and status stratification practices of their fellow owners force them to do identity work of their own to save face within the group with regards to their purchase. Male Porsche Cayenne SUV owners engage in hyper-masculine behaviors to compensate for their purchase and to gain entrée into the ingroup, similar to the practices observed in men who do not conform to hegemonic definitions of gender in the occupational, athletic, or personal spheres, such as male clerical workers, gay athletes, and men with physical disabilities, who negotiate social acceptance through overemphasizing their masculinity in other spheres (Anderson, 2002; Gershick & Miller, 1995; Henson & Rogers, 2001). Male Porsche Cayenne owners try to combat the anti-masculine stereotypes, positioning themselves as fellow enthusiasts and citing other Porsche sports cars that they own to claim legitimacy. They tell stories about how they take their SUVs off-road, use them to tow their race cars or their boats, or use them to access adventure sports such as skiing, hiking, hunting, and fishing, thereby tapping into other markers of masculinity. These owners refer to their SUVs as sports cars, speaking about them using sports car terminology.

I drive around all winter, up and down canyons, go skiing, into remote lakes on dirt roads and get paged to sprint back to the hospital all the time...Would I love cruising around in a cayenne knowing that if it dumps while I'm up at snowbird that I'll safely and surely make it back home or to the hospital no matter what and if it doesn't that I'll be able to push down those awesome twisty roads in little cottonwood? Definitely... Just so you don't think I'm trolling or have no experience with porsche... I have [Porsche] 996tt, used to have 84 [Porsche] turbo with upgraded turbo etc., had 81 [Porsche] euro 911 sc before that and have been reading everything I could get my hands on about them since I was 12. I love the car and think they've brought something new to the SUV/multipurpose car category with the cayenne turbo with its offroad abilities, handling and performance... I think the cayenne will get me most of the places this takes me (except one remote lake and MOAB trails) and get me home with more handling and zip.

The male Porsche Cayenne SUV owners brag about the technical performance of the vehicles and tell stories about beating sports cars at track events. With aggressive posturing, many of these men put down the other Porsche models. This behavior is an example of masculine one-upmanship, where men fighting to achieve status and recognition within a social group attempt to demonstrate their masculinity by conquering or dominating the weaker members of the group (Iacuone, 2005). Sensing an opportunity for one-upmanship, given the Porsche brand community's longstanding ostracism of the Porsche Boxster and 944/951 owners, the Porsche Cayenne SUV owners pit themselves (and their vehicles) against these weaker owners in an aggressive show of force to curry favor with the Porsche 911 owners who reign at the top of the status hierarchy.

The base Cayenne is still a 350 hp v8, and it definitely faster than a [Porsche] 944 is...And you'd be rather surprised at the Cayenne on a real track! There was an S model out at Sebring and the thing was blowing by [Porsche] Boxsters and [Porsche] 930s, and yes, [Porsche] 951s... Like I said, go drive one. It'll surprise the hell outta you. (dave120)...on a real track, smart stuff, it will eat your [Porsche] 951 alive.

Welcome to the 21st century, where the technology now has surpassed your and my 1980s technology... You continue to emit garbage, and until you go experience one of these 'school busses' for yourself you can't say what it is or is not capable of. Go, drive, believe. Till then shut your hole about oh the cayenne is a mistake this, and oh if I ran porsche things would be so much better... You seem sore that its faster than a [Porsche] boxer, I'm sure yours will edge it out, but still, faster than many sports cars. How many companies offer off road performance and blistering track times from the same vehicle? One. Porsche. The cayenne is here to stay, so why whine. (ERAU-944)

Despite this show of hypermasculinity, the Porsche sports car owners deny the Porsche Cayenne SUV owners entrée into the ingroup and pull their previously maligned Boxster brethren closer in a show of sports car family support.

No way, no how, could the Cayenne S beat the [Porsche] Boxster S on any smooth road or track. Absurd. It won't even begin to handle with it, won't begin to accelerate with it, has a lower top speed, and 60% more weight on a far higher center of gravity. I have driven the Cayenne S, it has neither the handling nor power of an Audi S6 Avant, and I can tell you the S6 won't catch a Boxster S anywhere either. (NMoore)

The technical performance of the Cayenne is largely irrelevant to the existing owners, who focus on the illegitimate owners who are trying to steal the sports car owners' masculinity marker. In this post, the Cayenne is portrayed as a “strap-on for soccer moms and effeminate stockbrokers,” illustrating its illegitimacy as a false phallus.

Porsche screwed the pooch on the Cayenne. It's great that it handles well... it's great that it goes fast... blah friggin blah. 99% of these abortions will be owned and driven by people who have no business with a fast anything, the only thing that will save them is that it can actually handle. The real issue is that Porsche was a company with a tremendous heritage of building one-off race cars for the street. It's entire existence is almost contrary to the last 40 years of Porsche history. How can you say, Porsche, there is no substitute about a vehicle that is so obviously nothing special? I can tow more with a Chevy, I can carry more in a [Ford] Expedition. Who cares how fast I can go, if I am going camping with a boat on the back? Only a fucktard would haul ass with his family in the car. I can get more luxury from Lexus in the LX470, I can get more bling in a [Mercedes-Benz] ML55. I can go further offroad in a Jeep, or even an International Scout. So what's left? An expensive strap-on for soccer-moms and effeminate stock-brokers. (Water944t)

In summary, the face-saving practices of the Cayenne owners highlight that these mistreated owners try to validate their ownership and their place in the group by closely adhering to the group's masculine identity standards. Facing exclusion, the men who purchase the SUV and who are relegated to the outgroup resort to a display of hyper-masculine behaviors to try to gain entry into the ingroup. These actions further reinforce the standards for masculine behavior in the brand community. The act of defining the ingroup causes the groups of consumers who previously saw themselves as heterogeneous (Porsche 911 and Boxster owners) to come together and celebrate their similarities. Adding gender diversity to the

community counter intuitively makes the group more homogeneous and devoted to the traditional notions of masculinity. The managers' attempts to gender-bend the Porsche brand paradoxically spur the brand community to solidify and defend the brand's status as a masculine identity marker.

5. Discussion

5.1. Theoretical contributions

First, this research shows that gender continues to exert a significant force on people in their choice and usage of brands. Despite the claims that we are living in a postmodern era of gender experimentation, the men in this study continue to value and protect the masculine identity meanings of their brands. When sufficient numbers of women appropriate a brand that is being used as a male identity marker, it disrupts the men's identity performances. Rather than making the brand "gender neutral" as suggested by Fischer and Gainer (1994) or "opening up the possibility for diverse gestures and characteristics" as suggested by Butler (1997), this incursion initiates collective self-presentation practices that solidify the brand's male-ness. Female gender contamination, initially recorded in ancient civilizations, is as potent today as it was in the past.

While instances of people using gender-bending consumption to experiment with their identities abound in the popular and academic literature (cf. Martin et al., 2006), this research shows that when male-gendered brands target the opposite sex, their male consumers can and do fight back. The fight over Porsche could reflect the greater battle that men are fighting to maintain their dominant position in the broader social hierarchy. When the boundaries between groups of unequal status and power become more permeable and when status hierarchies become unstable, the members of high status groups become motivated to maintain the status distinctions, increase ingroup identification, and increase outgroup discrimination (Sachdev & Bourhis, 1991). In contemporary society, these conditions are in place; the boundaries between men and women are becoming more permeable in the workplace, in the home, and in consumption, and the prevailing patriarchal power structure is under attack from women, gay men, and alternative definitions of manhood. Kimmel (1996) claims that rather than becoming more androgynous in response to the movements that are blurring gender boundaries, men, in an angry response to a world in which the attainment of hegemonic masculinity remains out of reach, are regressing toward behaviors that reinforce the traditional definitions of masculinity. This behavior makes gendered consumption more important today than it was in times when gender roles were less blurry. Masculine and feminine identity markers are more valuable to consumers when gender roles are permeable, making gendered consumption a powerful force in the postmodern era.

Second, these findings illustrate how consumers in brand communities engage in gender production. The consumers' communal response to gender-bending produces and reproduces the gender distinctions and hierarchies. The gender-bending of the Porsche brand, rather than blurring gender lines and contributing to a less hierarchical gender order, strengthens the gender distinction by reifying and reproducing hegemonic masculinity and solidifying its position at the top of the social hierarchy in the brand community. The reinstatement of the Porsche brand as a masculine identity marker shows that identity-driven consumption contributes to the regulative gender discourses that constrain both men and women in contemporary society. Gender-bending brands that are used by consumers for identity purposes ignite a discursive process, marked by power, that determines the gendered meaning of the brand in culture and reinforces the prevailing power structures. This process shows how the normative and ideological beliefs perpetuated by brand communities through the moralistic identity work highlighted by Luedicke et al. (2009) connect to

larger and more stable sociological constructs and structures, such as gender narratives.

Third, this research illuminates how the existing consumers phenomenologically respond to brand gender-bending practices, and it identifies a different response than that predicted by the prior experimental research. Prior research has shown that men choose possessions associated with masculinity and avoid possessions associated with femininity; therefore, researchers have hypothesized that men will abandon possessions once they have been contaminated by women. However, this research finds that the men who have invested themselves in a brand will fight for its meaning, territorially protecting their masculine identity markers from becoming associated with women. Rather than leaving their brand when it has been gender contaminated, the Porsche men engage in defensive practices within their brand community to actively defend their masculine identity marker and combat the feminization of their brand. This strategy supports our understanding of the co-creative process of brand meaning management among the consumers of a brand and underscores the importance of brand communities as spaces for creating value for consumers outside of, and sometimes in conflict with, the value provided by marketers.

The response of Porsche consumers contrasts with the findings from prior research that has focused on the appropriation of the identity markers of subordinate (rather than dominant) groups. Studies of subcultures whose symbols are appropriated by the mainstream (Clarke, 1986) find that members abandon identity markers once they are appropriated by the mainstream and find new ones with which to distinguish themselves. Rinallo (2007) shows that homosexual men, however, embrace the appropriation of their fashion and grooming markers by heterosexual men, viewing it as a way to gain mainstream acceptance of their alternative version of masculinity. In contrast, this article studies the appropriation of the identity markers of a dominant group, namely white, heterosexual men. This dominant group actively resists the appropriation of their identity marker brands and works to limit access to the brand's masculine identity meanings to those who embody their definition of masculinity. The distinctions between the findings of these diverse studies reminds us that gender politics still matter; the men who are at the top of the power structure actively resist when those on the rungs below them (including women and less masculine men) use their brands. While subcultures abandon their products when the dominant groups abscond with them, the dominant groups actively fight to maintain semiotic control of their markers of identity and actively work to prevent subordinate groups from appropriating them.

Fourth, the Porsche consumers' battle for their brand contributes to our understanding of how consumption practices impose social structure and social distinction within brand communities. Politicized ingrouping/outgrouping processes have been previously documented in brand community research (Muniz & O'Guinn, 2001; Muniz & Schau, 2005) that shows that the community members often view themselves as an ingroup and those who use the competitive brands as an outgroup, an inter-brand effect. However, the Porsche results show that this process can also be an intra-brand effect. Regardless of the brand moniker that one buys, entry into the ingroup is a communally negotiated process (Leigh et al., 2006). Consumers who buy the Porsche brand expecting entry into a social collective might find themselves excluded and ridiculed by those in the brand's communities who are pursuing their own political agendas.

When men refuse to share their masculine identity markers with women (or with men whom they deem inferior), these men reinforce their power advantage and buttress hegemonic masculinity as the prevailing cultural standard in their brand community. However, at the same time, through the gender stereotyping that elicits and reinforces recognizable pejorative subcategories within the gender spectrum, the existing Porsche owners contribute to the creation of a complex gender status hierarchy where the more nuanced gender identities beyond the male/female dichotomy, such as the soccer

mom, the poseur, and the yuppie, are defined and stratified. By defending their masculine identity markers, the men defend their position at the top of the gender order and suppress the alternative definitions of gender that are emerging for both men and women.

In conclusion, this research shows that the social practices that constitute gender continue to shape the meaning of brands and concomitantly shape the use and value of brands as gender identity markers by consumers. It also illustrates how the practices of gendered brand consumption contribute to the gendering of the social hierarchy and the regulative discourses that constrain both men and women in brand communities. This research helps us to better understand the continued presence and importance of gendered consumption in the postmodern world.

5.2. Future research

It is important to note that this study focuses on the common identity needs of a largely homogeneous population: the majority of the Porsche brand community is Caucasian, heterosexual, upper class, highly educated, white collar professionals. Their collective response to the launch of the SUV represents how men who are well endowed with the markers of masculinity respond to brand gender contamination. Men pursuing alternative forms of masculinity or those who are further from the hegemonic ideal are not represented, and research suggests that their responses could differ. The men who do not fit the typical profile associated with traditional masculinity can use gender-bending consumption to explore alternative forms of masculinity. Homosexual men can engage in feminine consumption practices to distance themselves from hegemonic definitions and to create their own definition of gay masculinity (Kates, 2002). African-American men can pursue a black masculinity populated with consumption items that would typically be classified as feminine such as jewelry (Weems, 2005). Women's responses to brand gender contamination are also not captured in this study. Women, as a subordinated group, might be more fluid when playing in the spaces between the dichotomous poles of masculine and feminine (Borgeson & Rehn, 2004) and might therefore perceive less of a threat from brand gender contamination.

The moderating role of other identities that intersect with gender is also left unexplored. Interesting intersections of gender with race and social class were evident in the data and suggest that stereotyping is used to define not only gender hierarchies but also racial and class ones. The Porsche brand community attaches pejorative racial and social class stereotypes to the SUV owners, such as the hip-hop rapper and the Southern redneck, to distance these users from the brand's more traditional masculine meanings. Further research that explores identity intersectionality and the simultaneity of gender, race, class, and sexual identities, and intersectionality's interaction with consumption behavior would be useful to further develop the theory because a brand's identity meanings are multifaceted and represent a desired identity defined by more than one identity category.

5.3. Managerial implications

Stagnant sales in many mature product categories are causing managers to look for new ways to increase business. A gendered brand necessarily ignores half of a potential audience, making it a ripe target for expansion. Gender-bending a gendered brand allows the marketers to tap into the large consumer segment occupied by the opposite sex. However, this decision is where the trouble often begins. When a gendered brand's identity meanings are diluted by its appropriation by the opposite sex, its existing consumers have two options: to discard the brand because it no longer delivers their desired gender identity (a strategy suggested by previous research) or to stay and fight for the gendered meanings that they use to present their identities, as presented here in this article. Either option

thwarts the manager's objective of increasing the brand's appeal to both sexes.

This study offers insight into the challenges of gender-bending brands. Before gender-bending, the managers need to assess how much of their brand equity derives from the brand's gendered identity meanings that are actively utilized by their consumers, gender-bending could be a high risk strategy. In this case, the managers should consider alternative branding strategies, such as the creation of a new brand to target the opposite sex; for example, Procter and Gamble offers its Old Spice brand for men and its Secret brand for women, hiding the corporate affiliation between the two brands from consumers to avoid gender contamination. If launching a new brand is too costly, marketers can launch gendered derivatives of their existing brands; for example, Gillette's women's products are branded "Gillette for Women," while Dove's men's products are branded "Dove for Men" to distinguish the brands and to reassure consumers that they are not using the same products as the opposite sex. For brands that are not used by consumers to communicate their gender identities, gender-bending is a more amenable strategy because the brand equity is not reliant on the gendered identity meanings of the brand. Thus, determining how central the gendered meanings are to the existing consumers is a key first step in deciding whether to gender-bend a brand.

Second, managers need to determine how contaminating usage by the opposite sex will be. When women ride Harley-Davidson's, they engage in gender tourism and empower their own femininities through a hyper-masculine display (Martin et al., 2006). The brand is useful to these women because of its masculine identity meanings, and their masculine creative play does not threaten the gendered meaning of the brand but rather reinforces it, as they are not trying to feminize the brand through their usage. However, the Porsche case illustrates the dangers when brand managers or the women they target position or use a masculine identity marker in more feminine ways. When a brand's manager actively courts women with feminized product designs, features, or brand narratives, the inherent gendered meanings of the brand are more likely to be diluted and male consumers might fight to protect them. As long as women respect the masculinity of the brand and act appropriately with it in their usage practices, Martin's research suggests that men will allow a certain degree of female patronization of their brand. However, when an incursion of women into the brand fundamentally changes the perceived masculinity of the brand in the eyes of the social audience, the men in brand communities mobilize to protect the identity meanings that they hold dear. Hence, women can use masculine brands as long as they respect their masculinity; the trouble begins when women (or the brand's managers) try to feminize the masculine identity markers.

Third, managers need to be ready for a backlash when they try to gender-bend masculine brands. This study shows that masculine brands become paradoxically more masculine following gender-bending brand management programs. Managers still need to heed the asymmetry inherent in gender relations and its differential impact on consumer behavior (Bristor & Fischer, 1993). Despite media-fueled images of gender-bending that suggest that the gender boundaries are breaking down, this article shows that contemporary men remain protective of their brands and will actively reject efforts to feminize them. Male consumers are likely to have negative responses to these gender-bending practices and can use tactics such as negative stereotyping to preclude women from accessing the brand's identity meanings. These actions reinforce the masculinity of the brand and cause consumers to display hyper-masculine behaviors to gain entry into the brand's community of owners. As such, the managers of masculine identity marker brands should be wary of gender-bending branding practices. Rather than stretching the brand's meaning to make it more flexible, these practices might paradoxically make the brand more male than ever before, precluding future brand expansion opportunities.

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